demands and Manipur's political future. Meiteis and Nagas, he argued, share worries over illegal immigration and SoO groups, and the Centre's approach to Kuki groups has fed distrust.

THE CONFLICT SPREADS

The violence soon engulfed the Imphal valley. On June 15 and 16, protests broke out outside the Regional Institute of Medical Sciences (RIMS) in Imphal after three Kuki youths were admitted there for treatment. They had been injured in an explosion in Kangpokpi's Leilon Munlui village. The protesters objected to their treatment at RIMS, located in Meitei-dominated Imphal, forcing authorities to tighten security around the hospital. On June 17, the three were transferred to Churachandpur Medical College under heavy escort.

Since the elected government returned on February 4, its response has remained largely reactive, imposing curfews and internet shutdowns, concentrating forces, ordering National Investigation Agency probes and negotiating local de-escalation after each flashpoint. In March, new chief minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh opened direct talks with the Kuki-Zo Council, and on April 1, Union home minister Amit Shah reviewed the situation in Manipur with him. But independent observers say the free flow of arms among civilians remains a major obstacle to peace. The police admit that only about 70 per cent of the looted weapons have been recovered so far.

Three years on, Manipur's divisions are growing more layered. The valley stays cut off from the hills, and the hills themselves are now splitting along ethnic lines. The hostage crisis of 2026 may mark a new phase in Manipur's conflict. ■

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

SP SEEKS FIRM HANDSHAKE

With the UP assembly election less than a year away, the SP and Congress leadership root for an alliance



HINDUSTAN TIMES

NEW WAVE Rahul Gandhi and Akhilesh Yadav at an Opposition alliance meet in Delhi

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

FOR MUCH OF THE PAST YEAR, the relationship between the Samajwadi Party (SP) and the Congress seemed fraught, with differences over parliamentary strategy, coordination within the INDIA bloc, the broader direction of Opposition politics all playing their part. Surprising, because, together, the two parties had delivered one of the biggest shocks of the 2024 Lok Sabha election in Uttar Pradesh, winning 43 seats (out of a total 80), sharply reducing the BJP's tally in a state considered one of its strongest fortresses.

The June 8 meeting of the Opposition INDIA bloc in Delhi appears to have reset the relationship. The timing is significant. UP goes to the polls in less than a year in 2027. Beyond the numbers, the 2024 results had shown that the alliance could consolidate anti-BJP votes across communities that had often voted at cross-purposes previously. With six seats, it had also restored a degree of relevance to the Congress in UP after years of decline, while giving the SP a broader coalition than it could have assembled on its own.

WALKING THE TALK

The alliance talks acquired some urgency after reports that the ruling Yogi Adityanath-led BJP government might advance the elections to November-December this year. This was reflected in SP chief Akhilesh Yadav's comment on June 14. Speaking to reporters at his home base Mainpuri, he painted a dire scenario: "If the BJP wins both the 2027 UP election and the next Lok Sabha poll,